

Going Live: What to Do to Run This App for Real

Right now the app runs on a test computer with practice data and a free offline stand-in for the "AI brains." This document is the plain-language checklist for taking it from prototype to a real creator with real fans.

Steps are in rough order. Each is tagged: - **You** can do it yourself - **Developer** needed - **Legal/admin**

There's a one-paragraph **shortcut** at the bottom if you just want to see it working for real as fast as possible.

1. Get permission from Instagram (with some developer help)

The app can only read posts and comments through Instagram's official doors.

- ☐ Create a free **Meta developer account** at developers.facebook.com.
- ☐ Register the app and set up **Instagram Login** (no Facebook Page needed).
- ☐ Connect **one Instagram account you own or control** first. This is "Standard Access" — it works immediately, no review required, and is enough to prove the whole product end to end.
- ☐ Submit **App Review (Advanced Access)** to connect other creators later. Request only the permissions the demo visibly uses (asking for extras is a common rejection reason). This can take days to weeks — **start it early**, in parallel with everything else.

Never scrape Instagram. Meta detects and blocks it and has taken legal action. Official API only.

Permissions the app uses: `instagram_business_basic`, `instagram_manage_comments`, `instagram_manage_messages`.

2. Turn on the real "AI brains" (costs money)

Today the AI is a free offline placeholder so the app runs with zero keys. For real quality, plug in paid providers (it's just pasting keys into a settings file — see `.env.example`):

- ☐ An **AI model** for answers, content ideas, and tagging (e.g. Anthropic or OpenAI). Set the latest capable model.
- ☐ An **embeddings** service that powers the search.
- ☐ **Transcription** (spoken words in videos) and **OCR** (text on screen). These can run locally for near-zero cost, or via a paid service.

Rough cost: tens of dollars to process one creator's entire back catalogue once, then cents per search after that. All providers are swappable by changing settings — you are never locked into one vendor.

3. Put it on the internet

Move it off the test computer onto a real server.

- ☐ Deploy to a **cloud server** (any provider — the app ships as standard containers via `infra/docker-compose.yml`).
- ☐ Stand up a real **database** (PostgreSQL) and **file storage** (for downloaded media).
- ☐ Buy a **domain name** (your `yourapp.com`) and serve the search page over HTTPS. Each creator lives at `yourapp.com/<their-handle>`.
- ☐ Point Instagram's **webhook** at the live server so comment replies work.

Effort: a few days for someone who has done a deployment before.

4. Cover the legal basics

You're storing what fans search and ask, so this is required (and Meta asks for it during App Review).

- ☐ Publish a **privacy policy**.
 - ☐ Provide a **deletion path** (a way for people to have their data removed).
 - ☐ The app already helps: audience questions are stored without names (pseudonymous), and deleting a creator's post removes it from search.
 - ☐ Consider basic **terms of service** for creators.
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5. Fill the two small product gaps (small jobs, don't block a pilot)

- ☐ **One-click creator sign-up.** Today an operator connects each account by hand via a command-line tool. Fine for the first creator; needed before scaling.
- ☐ **Email the weekly report.** Today the "what to post next" digest prints to a log instead of being emailed. Easy to add.

Neither blocks a first pilot — you can onboard one creator manually and read their report yourself.

6. Run a real pilot

- ☐ Pick **one creator** who fits: 100+ evergreen posts, an audience that asks lots of repeat questions, and at least one thing to sell (course, product, affiliate).

- ☐ Load their content, then have them spend **~2 hours labelling 40-60 real questions** (pulled from their existing comments) so the app's built-in "exam" can confirm it finds the right posts.
- ☐ **Keep auto-DM in approve-first mode** — every reply gets a human OK — until the exam passes its accuracy and citation checks.
- ☐ Have the creator put the **search link in their bio**, add a permanent "Search" Highlight, and actually tell their audience to use it.

The two questions the pilot answers: 1. Can a real fan find the right old post **faster than through Instagram**? 2. Does the creator **act on the weekly report** without being talked into it?

The shortcut (fastest path to "it works for real")

To see a real fan searching a real creator's archive, you mainly need **steps 1, 2, and 3**: your own Instagram account connected, paid AI keys pasted in, and the app running on a cloud server with a domain. Everything else — App Review for other creators, one-click sign-up, email, billing — is about scaling afterward, not proving it works.

What's already done (so you know what you're NOT paying to build)

- Search over captions, spoken words, and on-screen text, with cited answers
- The fan-facing search page (light/dark, mobile-first)
- Comment → drafted reply + DM, with human approval and Instagram's safety limits
- The weekly "what to post next" report (Demand Radar)
- Affiliate "buy" buttons with click tracking
- The built-in accuracy "exam" that gates the auto-DM feature
- Swappable AI providers, privacy-safe storage, and a full test suite

See `README.md` for how to run it locally and `docs/IMPLEMENTATION_PLAN.md` for the full technical plan.